

Charging into battle
A mounted samurai warrior charges into battle with an enemy clan, supported by foot soldiers *(above)*. A samurai's armour and weaponry took many forms. The *zunari bachi* (head-shaped) helmet *(right)* features a gold-lacquered frontal plate. The sheathed sword accompanying it typically had a blade 60cm (24in) in length.

THE SAMURAI WERE MOUNTED armoured warriors who enjoyed elite status in medieval Japanese society – in a sense, the Japanese equivalent of the European knight. Their code of chivalry, known as *bushido*, was based on the principle of absolute loyalty to the master they served. From the 12th century, samurai clans were the effective rulers of Japan under figurehead emperors. Samurai armies fought one another in interminable civil wars until the pacification of Japan under the Tokugawa shogunate in the 1600s.

The samurai originated as servants of the emperor, probably as early as the 8th century CE. They functioned as palace guards and upheld the emperor's authority in the provinces. Over time the samurai evolved into an aristocratic elite based on birth rather than function. The samurai warrior's true allegiance shifted from the emperor, whom he nominally served, to his own clan, or extended family. In the Gempei Wars (1180–85) – a turning point in Japanese history – two samurai clans fought for supreme power. The Minamoto family emerged triumphant, defeating their rivals the Taira. Minamoto Yoritomo was declared shogun, or military ruler, of Japan.

At the time of the foundation of the shogunate, the bow, rather than the sword, was the samurai's most prestigious weapon. It appears that the elite warriors regarded war as above all an opportunity to demonstrate individual fighting skill and courage. When opposing armies were drawn up on the battlefield, leading samurai would dismount and step forward to recite their ancestry and previous feats of arms. The two armies would then shoot their bows in a general exchange of arrows, after which samurai would seek out a suitable opponent to engage in single combat – it would be dishonourable for a samurai to fight someone of lesser standing than himself. This, at least, was the ideal to which the warriors aspired. At times battles were far more complicated, involving the use of both trickery and surprise. At Kurikara in 1183, the Minamoto army reportedly trounced the Taira by sneaking around their defensive position in a mountain pass and attacking them from the rear, while simultaneously driving a herd of oxen into their ranks from the front.

BUSHIDO AND SEPPUKU

Samurai of the 12th and 13th centuries were acutely aware of their elite status. A warrior was expected to show both literary and artistic refinement, as well as military virtues. A samurai's training was often accomplished by the bonding of a young warrior to a veteran, a complex relationship in which homosexual love played its part. The samurai code of behaviour – initially formalized as *kyuba no michi* (the way of horse and bow) and later as *bushido* (the way of the warrior) – emphasized the need for absolute self-control, restraint, and the avoidance of any ostentation. Some of the customs that were observed in samurai warfare were a strange mixture of the savage and civilized. For instance, it was considered normal for a warrior to cut off the head of any man he killed in battle as evidence of his prowess. The severed head would then be washed, groomed, and prettified with cosmetics before being mounted on a spiked board. If the head belonged to a warrior of high standing, it would be considered honourable to return it to his family.



SAMURAI HELMET AND SWORD IN SCABBARD